

Euphemism and Moral Distance Classroom Run Kit

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and Language • 20-25 min

Category	Knowledge and Language	Time	20-25 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	euphemism-and-moral-distance

Big idea: Language can hide responsibility.

One-Minute Teacher Brief

Students examine how language can hide agency or responsibility.

Student Prompt

Inspect Euphemism and Moral Distance Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Euphemism and Moral Distance Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Paired terms such as 'collateral damage' and 'civilian deaths'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Euphemism and Moral Distance Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Workplace or political language that softens responsibility. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Euphemism and Moral Distance Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A moral-distance scale showing how language changes judgement. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Language can hide responsibility.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Euphemism and Moral Distance Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Euphemism and Moral Distance Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	Can language make unethical actions seem acceptable?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and Language.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how language can hide responsibility.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Student Instructions

- Work silently for the first response so you can notice your own starting point.
- Record one knowledge claim, the evidence behind it, and your confidence level.
- After the reveal or comparison, update your claim in a different colour or column.
- Use the debrief to answer: Can language make unethical actions seem acceptable?

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: Paired terms such as 'collateral damage' and 'civilian deaths'.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Example Stimuli or Materials

- Paired terms such as 'collateral damage' and 'civilian deaths'.
- Workplace or political language that softens responsibility.
- A moral-distance scale showing how language changes judgement.

Resources To Use

- Resource pack: <resources/euphemism-and-moral-distance/index.html>
- Card deck CSV: <resources/euphemism-and-moral-distance/cards.csv>
- Visual prompt: <resources/euphemism-and-moral-distance/visual-prompt.svg>
- Printable student worksheet with observation, inference, evidence, and confidence columns.
- Teacher notes with setup checklist, sample facilitation language, misconceptions, and assessment look-fors.
- Classroom run kit with prompt cards, example stimuli, and debrief moves.
- PowerPoint deck with a student-facing sequence for running the activity.

Run Sequence

1. Students rank each phrase pair from most direct to most distancing.
2. They identify who benefits from the softer phrase.
3. Groups rewrite each phrase in clearer language.
4. Discuss when tact becomes distortion.

Debrief Moves

- Knowledge question: Can language make unethical actions seem acceptable?

- Is precise language an ethical responsibility?
- How do institutions control knowledge through vocabulary?

Teacher Quick Script

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...